

The True Cost Worksheet

FILL IN TOGETHER

Adds up the costs that never appear in the sticker price — flights home, a laptop, the deposit, the winter coat — so the first year holds no expensive surprises.

When: Before you fall in love with a school, not after

What the college charges

Item	Per year

What the college does not charge you for, but you pay anyway

Item	Per year

Commonly missed: enrolment deposit · housing deposit · travel home at breaks (multiply by number of trips) · laptop · textbooks and access codes · lab or studio fees · winter clothing · phone plan · toiletries and laundry · club or Greek dues · health insurance if you cannot waive it · storage over summer · a flight for move-in for you as well.

The four-year picture

Total we pay in year one

Assume 4% more each year — total across four years

Of that, how much is borrowed

Monthly repayment on that debt after graduation

WORTH KNOWING

- ◆ A rough rule: do not borrow more in total than the student expects to earn in their first year of work.
- ◆ Costs rise every year. Budgeting year one four times over is optimistic.
- ◆ Ask whether the health insurance charge can be waived. It is often over \$2,000.